Ashkelon while doing a live television interview. Since then, the newspaper had hired a bodyguard to accompany him on reporting trips.

The cause of this was a column he had published a week earlier, entitled *hara'im l'tayyis*—literally, "the worst to the air force", a subversion of the well-known phrase *hatovim l'tayyis*, "the best to the air force", a slogan adopted by the service decades ago to boost enlistment. He lamented that none of the pilots refused to serve in the war: "Are they really like robots?":

> They are the best of all, brother—they are the best to the air force, the best pilots, and now they do the worst deeds, the most cruel and vile. They have never seen an enemy plane in front of them—the service's last aerial battle took place before most of them were even born… they are heroes over the weak, the weakest, the powerless who do not even have an air force or air defense, barely even a kite.[26]

A controversial column, even for *Ha'aretz*, which published a rejoinder to itself two days later. But not a new one. Levy himself pointed out that he had published "almost word-for-word the same article" in 2008, during Operation Cast Lead.[27] "And then it passed, you know? There were many people furious at me, but nothing like the atmosphere now." Hours after the interview was published, Levy appeared on Channel 2 for an interview, and was quickly shouted down by an angry local resident. "You're a traitor," the man yelled. "You say that our pilots are murderers. Tell me, are you not ashamed? Do you have to live with Hamas? Our pilots are the most moral."[28]

It was not an isolated incident. Levy said he was constantly heckled for his politics throughout the war, even by his own bodyguards. Yariv Levin, a Knesset member from Likud and the chairman of the ruling coalition, suggested that Levy should be prosecuted for treason, calling him an "enemy mouthpiece" and the "lowest kind of provocateur".[29]

"I've never had it so harsh, so violent and so tense," Levy told me. "I'm quite experienced with public criticism, even with threats, attacks, but the recent days have really been the worst of all."

Levy often appears on international media, and his articles are widely shared by pro-Palestinian activists in the West. In Israel his following is far more limited; he is more of a canary in the coal mine, or—as his colleague Chemi Shalev called him—a "journalistic Iron Dome", a "lightning rod for angry outbursts, ever-multiplying, as the Israeli public's temper heats and its tolerance expires."